

Episode 110: Once Upon a Time... (66) *Sailor Moon R* Movie: The Secret of Moon Revenge

Today (December 22nd) is this year's winter solstice. Even Tokyo, which they say gets warmer each year due to global warming and other factors, has felt properly "winter-like!" these past few days. The nighttime and early morning chill has become quite formidable.

With less than 10 days left in this year, how is everyone spending their time?

Last weekend, I finally managed to make it to the theatres myself—for *Strong World ONE PIECE FILM*. I've already watched the main feature more times than I care to count during production, but I couldn't very well send my wife to the movie theatres alone when she wanted to go, plus I wanted to confirm how the colour corrections I'd requested from the lab during the final preview screening turned out in the print. But more than anything, I wanted to watch it surrounded by lots of customers and feel their reactions.

So Saturday night, I went to Marunouchi Toei in Tokyo's Ginza. Right below Toei's head office. By the way, I always wonder why this theatres is called "Marunouchi Toei" when it's in Ginza.

While it wasn't quite the frenzy of opening day last week, thanks to everyone, it was still bustling even a week later. As of last weekend, Marunouchi Toei was still distributing actual copies of the "Volume Zero" comic, and the pamphlets that were selling out everywhere were properly on sale. As expected from being right under the head office! So I impulsively bought one myself (laugh).

That theatres pamphlet uses quite a lot of colour samples and is quite luxurious, and most of those are colour samples that I coloured myself during the colour decision process.

Well, when stuff you painted yourself is obviously featured like that, it's happy on one hand, but somehow makes you break out in a weird sweat (laugh). Is it embarrassing? Ah, that's not quite it either. Well, actually some incorrectly painted colour sample data made it in there too, so that part is embarrassing (wry laugh).

Having done this kind of work for many years, I should be used to such things, but this time the "exposure" across various fronts is exceptionally high, and encountering it in so many different places might be making it feel extra strange.

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM will still be playing into the new year, so those who couldn't make it by year's end, GO during New Year's!

Now then.

I apologise for the extremely scattered pace, but continuing the *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R* movie story. I think you've all probably noticed by now that my pen isn't making much progress (explosion). To be honest, my memories of producing *Sailor Moon R* movie are quite vague.

It's probably because we rushed through such a short schedule at the time? Like the memories passed by before they could solidify. Hmm. There just wasn't any schedule. The things I mentioned earlier, like the staff room story—I remember the early period quite clearly, but the roughly one month from when work started coming to me until completion was truly a torrential state of affairs. So it's super vague.

At the time we were still in the analogue era, of course. We painted on cels with paints, finished them, and shot on film. Key animation reaches me → colour direction on key animation → in-between animation & painting work → cels painted in about 5 days → cel inspection & photography → rushes check. Every day was this repetition. That kind of month. In that flow, that it turned out reasonably well was probably because, even

with no time, we properly did the decision-making work and got director approval—I think that's the process we followed, but I don't really remember!

Well, most scenes could go with so-called "normal" colours... oh right, come to think of it, there were only a few key scenes where we properly did colour checks—like the rooftop evening scene, the hospital room in the flashback image, stuff like that (sweat).

In today's digital painting era, for example, even if cuts don't have properly finalised colour direction, you can send them to key animation and finishing (仕上げ) anyway, have the painting proceed with "normal" or "dummy colours," then after they're painted, place them on backgrounds to decide colours and repaint the digital painting data before sending to photography (actually, we make things quite routinely in that manner). But in the cel finishing era, naturally such repainting was impossible.

And so, "colour direction is reflexes" became increasingly the case. We'd do some degree of scene-by-scene decisions, then "instinctively" apply colour direction to key animation on the spot. And truly, "colour direction is reflexes"—this is one of my theories.

Whether it's key animation or in-between animation, when cuts come around for colour direction, you face them for serious combat. When amazing key animation comes around, you get goosebumps and think "Alright!" and fight it, and when bad animation comes around, you curse at that key animation (not the key animator, but the key animation itself) thoroughly, then decide whether to send it back to the assistant director for animation retake, or proceed as-is and fix it somehow after colours are applied—this too is decided through colour direction. Handling such things quickly while fully visualising the final painted result for colour direction.

That's why I can't quit colour direction. Design alone isn't satisfying (laugh). ...Ah, I'm getting a bit off track (wry laugh).

Anyway, it was definitely a month of fighting with wonderful key animation.

The colour story for the story's climax, the Silver Crystal scene. Those who've seen it might remember—the scene where the famous song "Moon Revenge" plays, Sailor Moon appears in a white dress, everyone's flashback images overlap, everyone's power combines, and the Silver Crystal reaches maximum power. For this scene, Director Ikuhara and I actually had a difference of opinion.

For Sailor Moon and the others in the light, I finished them with a stronger high-contrast "normal-style" colour scheme—a step up from previous scenes—but the director's image was different. He wanted that scene to have the characters overall bathed more in pink light, a so-called "pink tone" strong high contrast. So after the rushes came up—or was it during the shoot preparation (the work of combining backgrounds and cels before sending to photography to add photography instructions)—we had a disagreement. Well, Director Ikuhara said, "This is a bit different from what I was thinking."

Actually, I wasn't entirely unaware of Director Ikuhara's intent, but I was concerned that if I made the cel colours pink-toned in pink light, the characters would blend too much with the light colour and I wouldn't be able to effectively utilise their expressions. So I deliberately finished them with "normal-style" strong contrast colours without shifting toward pink.

Director Ikuhara pondered and groaned for a while, but we decided to shoot with the cel colours I'd created for now. "If we watch it and still think 'this is wrong,' then we'll retake, okay?" Director Ikuhara said. There certainly wasn't much time left, and honestly, it was a photography-intensive scene. Actually, retake reshoots are something you don't want to do unless absolutely necessary. Even while saying that, perhaps the director had already decided at that moment to go with the colours I'd produced no matter what.

When we watched the rushes later, we ultimately didn't retake and let me push through the climax with my approach.

And so, *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R* movie was somehow completed two weeks before its public release. However, the "price" of the torrential schedule remained as "rough spots" scattered throughout the screen. So Director Ikuhara, at the wrap party after the staff preview, directly appealed to President Tomari (current advisor): "This movie will definitely be a hit, so please let us do additional retakes for the laserdisc & video version!" The theatrical release couldn't be helped, but he wanted to do something about the LD & video version that would remain for posterity. And well, amazingly, he got President Tomari's "OK!" (wry laugh).

And, well, naturally there was some friction with the production department (wry laugh), but thus several of the really disappointing cuts from the theatrical release version were corrected and became the DVD version we can watch today.

Oh right, writing this reminded me—there was an old single-seat sofa in the staff room back then. I secretly called that sofa the "king's chair," and that imitation leather sofa was wonderfully soft and was the perfect item for sleeping.

And it was always a competition between me and Assistant Director Igarashi for that sofa. If the sofa was free, we'd nap there. If it was occupied, we'd go home to sleep (explosion). It seems somewhat backwards, but that's how much we wanted to stay at the studio working—I think our focus was that concentrated on the project.

This *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R* movie, thanks to everyone, became a big hit. And receiving this big hit, *Sailor Moon* theatrical versions would continue to be made the following year and the year after that.

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